

The Indian Gaming Industry

The Indian gaming development industry is still a niche industry, though rapid inroads are being made.

Some of the pioneers in the field are Indiagames, Dhruva Interactive, and Vbeing. You also have online game offerings from **Nazaragames.com**, **Contests2win.com** and **Gamesmasti.com**.

Dhruva Interactive: Developers of the 3D technology demo titled *Saloon*, and the game *Mission: Impossible*, Dhruva Interactive develops games for overseas clients.

Address: Dhruva Interactive, 946, 12th Main, 5th Cross, HAL 2nd Stage, Indiranagar, Bangalore 560 008.

Phone: 080-5267091

E-mail: info@dhruva.com

Web site: www.dhruva.com

Indiagames.com: The developers of India's first 3D shooting game titled *Yodha - The Warrior*, Indiagames develops games for the Internet, CD-ROMs, touch screen kiosks, gaming consoles, etc.

Address: Indiagames.com Ltd, 4A, Diamond House, 35th Road, Off Linking Road, Bandra (West), Mumbai - 400 050.

Phone: 022-649 6712/3

E-mail:

jobs@indiagames.com

Web site: www.indiagames.com

Vbeing Software: Having started out as a company to provide customised software solutions for e-commerce, Vbeing has branched out into game development as well.

Address: Vbeing Software Limited, G-29, Lajpat Nagar III, New Delhi.

Phone: 011-6821329

E-mail:

develop@vbeing.com

Web site: www.vbeing.com

the guy falling off a castle?) and human anatomy (so you can get all of Lara Croft's curves in the right places!) will add to your proficiency as a designer. So will a fundamental knowledge (at least) of programming aspects. You need to understand the technical aspects of the platform for which your game is being designed. Only then would you be able to create models effective enough for your system to support. For instance, when a game is designed to run on a system with an 8 MB graphics card, as a designer, you need to keep the hardware constraints in mind. If you churn out graphics that require higher capabilities than what the card can provide, the game is bound to mess up.

Programmed to work right

The importance of designing aside, the real magic lies in interweaving all those graphic objects into a game. This is where the programmer steps in.

The programming field also involves several levels—the lead programmer, 3D programmer, gameplay programmer and the network programmer. How can one get into one of these jobs, you ask? A true and undiluted love for gaming, coupled with some sound programming knowledge will take you there.

As a beginner, you need, first of all, a good knowledge of OOPs fundamentals. You need to have an in-depth understanding of languages such as C and C++ if you want to develop a 3D game in particular. Learning the ins and outs of Windows programming with tools such as Visual C++ is also very useful. And if you can get the grasp of assembly language, nothing like it.

A good grasp of the fundamentals of embedded C++ is essential for developing games for Pocket PCs and Java-based development tools for the Palm OS. Developing games for mobile phones calls for an understanding of WAP technology. A thorough knowledge of Flash or Director helps if you have a penchant for online games. Other tools that can be used are JavaScript, ASP, VBScript, etc. Oh, and did we mention a good understanding of scripting for game engines such as the A4, *Quake* or *Unreal Tournament* engine?

However, merely being good with C or C++ is not going to get you anywhere. You have to know the tools you use in and out as well as the platform for which your game is being designed. Other than the quintessential tools, you also need sufficient knowledge of mathematics,

physics, computer architecture, AI and expert systems and networks. Knowledge of DirectX and OpenGL is also necessary. Knowledge of graphics-related aspects such as using colour palettes, image optimisation, etc is always a plus point for a programmer. You also need to understand aspects such as porting which, put simply, involves getting a game designed for Windows to also work in Linux.

Before you take the plunge though, it always helps to gain some professional insight. Meet Nitesh Wadekar, Project Manager, Indiagames.com who started his career as a Web programmer, then went on to multimedia programming and finally game programming. Says Nitesh, "Programming games is not like standard programming. A game programmer requires more logic, even a lot of creativity. Even an excellent Java programmer cannot get into game programming unless he has that special something in him."

Rolling out your own game

So you've mastered the tools required. Now



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[Vinay P. Namboodiri](#)

Graphics Department, NCSE

what? The best way to get noticed by the industry is to develop your own game. "It is always best to try developing a simple 2D game using sprites (cells in an animation) at first. This will help you out in understanding and getting the basics of game programming right," says Vinay P. Namboodiri, who works at the National Centre for Software Engineering's (NCST) graphics department.

You can start off with simple 2D games such as *Hangman*, *Tic-Tac-Toe* or *Tetris* in C, C++ or some other language, rather than a full-fledged 3D game. You can even use Director for games with a presentable level of graphics. Be careful not to overdo the graphical elements as it tends to make the game slow and also, this is your first step buddy! A demo with just one level is more than enough to showcase your talent. Make sure that the game you're working on is the kind that you like to play so you can do full justice to it.

Now comes the time to test your creation. Get some of your friends and people you know to play it. Their feedback will be very useful in